terracotta figurines, featuring yakshas and yakshis, cult goddesses symbolizing fertility, animals and so on, often worn as pendants. Carpenters, shoemakers, weavers, farmers, homemakers and experts in weapons and transport technology move from shop to shop, choosing their wares from a range of finely built iron tools and artefacts. We can smell the smoke of the nearby brick kilns.

When a deal is struck, payment is made in the coins of the realm. The Ikshvakus minted their own currency in lead coins.[14] Considerable seaborne trade between Rome and the east coast of India supplies exotic goods for sale, like amphorae and Roman coins. We might see coins issued by emperors Tiberius (16–37 CE), Hadrian (117–38 CE) and Antoninus Pius (138–161 CE). In fact, we notice a local fad of people wearing Roman coins as pendants! We witness a tussle in which a shopkeeper denounces a buyer as a purveyor of counterfeit Roman coins, which are flooding the local markets.[15] The roots of such creativity run deep in India.

Merchants and trade guilds have a powerful presence in the city, as do guilds of artisans, masons, bricklayers, tile-makers, potters, blacksmiths, confectioners and more. As a big centre of Buddhist learning, with famous teachers like Nagarjuna, Aryadeva, Dharmanandi and others,[16] the lively streets of Vijayapuri also host a colourful mix of visitors and students from many parts of India and Sri Lanka, and even an occasional one from China, alongside Brahminical priests, Buddhist monks and nuns, poets, scribes, healers, tax collectors, produce sellers, sweepers, tailors, dancers, musicians, wrestlers, and other entertainers.

Along Vijayapuri's major arteries are public baths and several pillared halls with flat roofs that serve as rest houses for traders, students, pilgrims and other visitors to this capital city that readily embraces and propagates new ideas. We see water wells and tanks, and irrigation canals fed from the river. We pass a couple of edifices with the inscription *vigata-jvar-ālaya*, 'a place for those recovering from fever', which modern scholars believe were hospitals.[17] We pass a public assembly hall and people gathered at platforms near temples to play dice, a favourite pastime. One hall, seemingly a 'club', has drinking and dancing scenes carved on its pillars, including exotic outsiders like Scythians and Kushans in their distinctive